accounts, seven hundred thousand people were massacred; some contemporary chroniclers put the total at more than a million. At Nishapur, four hundred useful artisans were spared. Everyone else was beheaded; the Mongols piled the heads of the men in one place, the heads of women and children in another. Two massacres were carried out in Balkh, one when the city first fell, a second after the false withdrawal of Genghis's men lured survivors out of the nooks and crannies where they had hidden. "Wherever a wall was left standing," writes the thirteenth-century historian Juvaini, "the Mongols pulled it down and for a second time wiped out all traces of culture from that region."[9]

Meanwhile, Jalal ad-Din had claimed his father's title of Shah of Khwarezm, and was gathering himself to attack the Mongol rear. Receiving word that the new Shah's forces had managed to defeat a Mongol outpost, Genghis Khan turned and began to ride eastward, back towards India. His vendetta against the Shah was still alive; he traveled, says Juvaini by day and night, not even stopping for food. He caught up with Jalal ad-Din on the banks of the Indus river, and drove him and his men steadily backwards into the water. Most of the Shah's men were killed by Mongol arrows as they struggled in the water; the whole river, Juvaini writes, was "red with the blood of the slain." Jalal ad-Din himself managed to flounder through the Indus on horseback and emerged on the other side, only to flee into the distance. His wives and children, left behind, were taken captive; all of his male children were put to death.[10]